

Digital Marketing Practices in Ekiti State University Theatre: A Case Study of the 2025 Festival of Plays

ADEBIYI, Rukayat Olabisi

Department of Theatre and Media Arts,
Ekiti State University, Ado-Ekiti, Nigeria.
rukayat.adebiyi@eksu.edu.ng | 08138989047

Abstract

The advent of digital technology has introduced new ways of producing, sharing, and consuming information in the performing arts. This paper examines the impact of digital marketing on audience patronage and engagement of the 2025 festival of plays at the Department of Theatre and Media Arts, Ekiti State University. Digital technology offers Nigerian theatres opportunities to extend performances beyond the stage and open avenues for participatory relationships with audiences. Yet, university theatres in Nigeria continue to rely on a one-way marketing approach that primarily focuses on attracting people to the theatre. Employing a qualitative research method that includes participant observation, semi-structured interviews, and content analysis, this study explores the marketing strategies employed, challenges encountered, and results achieved during the festival of plays. Findings revealed that the strategies were largely unidirectional and did not significantly influence audience engagement. Digital platforms were mainly used as virtual notice boards for announcing performances and circulating posters, rather than as interactive platforms for dialogue, participation, and feedback. The results showed that although the strategies created visibility, they failed to foster sustained interaction with the audience. Consequently, this paper argues that Nigerian university theatres must move beyond using digital platforms as static announcement boards and embrace them as dynamic spaces where audiences actively contribute to marketing and production processes. It recommends that Nigerian university theatres establish dedicated marketing teams for their productions, adopt structured content calendars for publicity, and build capacity in digital communication to transform online platforms into effective spaces for audience engagement and collaborative participation.

Keywords: Theatre Marketing, Digital Technology, Social Media, Audience Engagement, Nigerian University Theatre

Introduction

Effective marketing is the soul of any theatre business. The business of the theatre thrives in an environment where it is widely known and accepted by its prospective audiences, and they are willing to exchange their resources to

acquire the theatre experiences. This view is supported by Ekweariri, who notes that “theatre productions are conceived, rehearsed, put together and presented for audience members whose continual patronage ensures the survival of the theatre” (cited in Ekweariri 94). Ekweariri's position points to the fact that a theatre cannot succeed if it remains unknown or unaccepted within its community and beyond.

Furthermore, the worldwide economic recession, which has significantly reduced the purchasing power of theatre consumers and intensified global competition among theatres and other entertainment industries, has made it essential for theatres worldwide to reassess their approaches to reaching and engaging the audience on critical issues that affect them and society at large. Approaches that embody a platform for sustained collaboration between the theatre and its audiences are preeminently important in this digital age to maintain the relevance of the theatre and build trust that encourages effective engagement with the end consumers.

The role of digital media in reshaping the marketing process of theatre cannot be jettisoned. Certainly, in recent years, digital technology and social media have emerged as powerful tools for communication and audience engagement. The world of arts has undergone an incredible transformation, and the introduction of new digital innovation (DI) in the form of services, platforms, and tools remains relentless (Mandviwalla and Ford 2). The proliferation of these new digital innovations is rapidly changing the way performing arts institutions reach and interact with their audiences, compelling these institutions to create more avenues for interaction and audience engagement. Digital technologies, the interactive innovation software that has significantly expanded the space of the theatre stage in its immanent genre-specific context (Tonkoshkura 30), now play a significant role in theatre promotion and influencing audience purchase intention.

Theatre, a once community-centered experience that relied on posters, handbills, and word of mouth to engage audiences, now competes in the same attention economy as Netflix, YouTube, and other digital entertainment platforms. The tech-savvy consumers of entertainment are continuously served contents on the digital spaces, giving the entertainment platforms that have leveraged the interactive features of online technologies high chance of

gaining visibility and building loyal, diverse audiences, especially among younger, tech-savvy groups who are raised in an internet-dependent environment (Zehra, Karamat, & Qureshi, 610), subjecting those that lagged in the use of these features to abject struggle for relevance.

Considering the stiff competition for the attention of the ever-engaged audience, traditional marketing approaches used in Nigerian theatres, particularly at Ekiti State University theatre, are increasingly inadequate in a digital age where platforms like TikTok, WhatsApp, and Instagram now shape how audiences consume and respond to entertainment. This study, therefore, examines the gaps in digital marketing practices in Nigerian University Theatres and argues for a shift towards more structured, participatory, and skill-driven approaches to audience engagement in the digital age. This study aims to address the research question: *How have the marketing strategies employed during the 2025 Festival of Plays at Ekiti State University Theatre influenced audience engagement and theatre promotion in the digital age?* The objectives are to identify the marketing tools used, assess their effectiveness in building a lasting relationship between the theatre and the audiences, and examine the challenges encountered in the marketing process.

Theoretical Framework

This paper adopts Berry's Relationship Marketing Theory (RMT) to drive its discourse on shifting the focus of theatre marketing from the primary goal of securing immediate ticket sales to a relational motive, which emphasizes trust, dialogue, commitment, and the co-creation of value between the theatre and its audiences (Berry 1983; Grönroos 1994). This paper draws from this framework to provide a strong foundation for understanding how theatre can cultivate long-term, interactive relationships with its audiences in the digital age.

Berry's Relationship Marketing Theory

This study is anchored on Berry's Relationship Marketing Theory, which posits that attracting new customers should be viewed only as an intermediate step in the marketing process. Developing a closer relationship with these customers and turning them into loyal ones are equally important aspects of marketing. According to Berry, relationship marketing is attracting, maintaining, and, in multi-service organizations, enhancing customer relationships (25).

The central premise of RMT is that marketing effectiveness in contemporary

contexts depends not only on attracting new consumers but also on sustaining meaningful connections with them over time. In the theatre, this implies moving beyond using posters and flyers to invite people to the theatre, to strategies that nurture ongoing communication and participation. Trust, commitment, communication, and conflict handling are the key components of relationship marketing (Berry 1983), which align with the expectations of today's audiences who seek immersive and participatory cultural experiences. Trust refers to the firm belief in the theatre's ability to deliver authentic and rewarding experiences. This confidence can be instilled in the audience through consistent publicity, behind-the-scenes content, and interactive engagement that assures the audience of value. Building and sustaining audience loyalty requires more than exposure; it demands experiences that make the audience feel valued, involved, and connected. The decision to engage with the theatre is usually influenced by the trust the audiences have in the ability of theatre to deliver quality performances that adds value to them. For instance, the teasers and trailers for *Women of Owu* during the 2025 festival of plays signaled quality and seriousness before the performance, and this connected the audiences emotionally and psychologically to the performance. Commitment indicates the efforts made by the theatre to maintain relationships with its audience and sustain these relationships beyond individual productions. Audiences are more likely to remain loyal when they perceive long-term dedication. Mark (2014) affirms that persistent digital engagement during the creative process facilitates contextualization and cognitive decoding, which improves kinaesthetic and emotional engagement during an ensuing live performance. Such commitment is essential for the sustainability of Nigerian theatre, where persuasion and cultural identification must be continuous.

Communication refers to the exchange of information and emotion between the theatre and its audience. The concept of communication emphasises the importance of dialogue and feedback. It is not just about speaking but creating an avenue to be talked back to. Understanding and interacting with customers at every stage of their journey is a key component of modern relationship marketing (Johanesova & Vanova, cited in Seaman & Critchlow, 1813). Within this framework, theatres are viewed not as businesses merely selling tickets, but as cultural institutions cultivating enduring connections with their audiences. The transactional approach embodied in posters, flyers, or ticket

campaigns gives way to a relational orientation that prioritizes dialogue, loyalty, and co-created value. The relational approach allows the audience talk back to the theatre and participate in the creation of meaning around the production. Nwafor and Eyefia (2019) show that social media strengthens these relational ties by encouraging active involvement. When audiences comment, like, or share theatre content online, they are not just consuming information but participating in the creation of production narratives.

Conflict handling denotes how theatres manage dissatisfaction or challenges that threaten relationships. In Nigeria, infrastructural and technical limitations often disrupt digital marketing. The ability for the theatre to respond and put in place remedial measures help preserve loyalty and sustain audience trust. When the pain points of the audiences are addressed and solutions proffered to their problems, such audiences tend to be emotionally connected to the theatre, and would always want to engage with the theatre.

Using these four dimensions of RMT, this study evaluates how marketing strategies employed during the 2025 Festival of Plays at Ekiti State University Theatre shaped audience engagement.

Literature Review

Theatre Marketing and the Digital Media

Scholarship on theatre marketing has increasingly examined how performances are promoted, positioned, and communicated to audiences within an evolving media landscape, emphasizing that the process of getting the audience to the theatre goes far beyond just persuading them to buy tickets and watch a show. It involves a range of interconnected activities that include researching, promoting, selling, and distributing theatre offerings in the most appealing way. Theatre marketing, according to Kalu (cited in Nwafor & Eyefia 116), is “associated with all the activities, processes and organizations for the creation, communication, and distribution of goods and services that have value and capable of satisfying individual and various societal needs and wants”. One of the key components of marketing the theatre and its offerings is communication. Essentially, marketing, which involves effective communication through the right channels, is a way of initiating conversations with the desired target audience to pique their interest in the surrounding events. Through effective marketing, awareness of societal happenings is created, interest in the situation is built, and a desire to contribute meaningfully

to discussions about the incident is encouraged, leading to actions that promote societal betterment.

Ultimately, the main goal of mobilizing audiences for dialogue that leads to positive change can be achieved if theatre marketers begin to deploy social marketing strategies that incorporate the tools and techniques of digital media, such as hashtags, targeted campaigns, and influencer collaborations, among others. Maulidiyanti et al. opine that social marketing is “the use of marketing ideas and practices to persuade a target audience to voluntarily accept, reject, change, or abandon a behavior for the benefit of people, groups, or society” (576). Thus, for theatre to reach a large audience and persuade them to engage in activities that foster societal benefits, there must be concrete efforts to align its marketing strategies with the creative expectations and digital habits of the target audiences. In view of the foregoing, the innovative use of digital technology by Nigerian live theatre marketers in promoting their productions becomes especially significant.

The advent of digital technology has significantly impacted the modus operandi of every sector, including the performing arts, and compelled the performing arts industry, particularly those committed to remaining spaces for expression, dialogue, and voicing of public concerns, to adopt and adapt technology-driven methods to their strategies of exchanging messages with their highly “technified” environments. The relevance of digital technology in the world of the performing arts is rightly pointed out by Tonkoshkura when he emphasises that “digital technologies are a resource used to ensure the interaction between actors and the audience. They aim to create a unique atmosphere of conversation with the audience” (31). Adopting and adapting technology-driven strategies in all aspects of its communication with audiences has become expedient for all performing arts in this digital era. Every aspect of audience engagement now demands digital consciousness. Corroborating this, BOH & Adoka, in their works on technological advances of the digital era and their impact on the performing arts/theatre, surmise that:

Theatre is no exception to the reality of technological imperative, its processes and applications. This is because of the way and manner in which theatrical products are created, produced, distributed, marketed, preserved and supported are shifting (in some instances, being transformed) in relation to the apparently digital transition of society. (27)

The above assertion affirms that the digital transition of society has created a new environment in which theatre must operate. Theatre must now position itself within the digital spaces where audiences are already deeply engaged and continuously connected.

Participatory Audiences and the Digital Cultural Labour

Digital cultural labour refers to the forms of creative, promotional, and interactive work that take place on digital platforms. It extends beyond traditional artistic labour to include the unpaid or underpaid activities of both creators and audiences. Scholars describe it as the effort invested in creating and sustaining visibility in digital spaces, often through activities like producing content, sharing, liking, commenting, remixing, and curating (Scholz, 2013; Terranova, 2000). For theatres and performance, this labour includes the production, circulation, and consumption of artistic works, and by extension, audience participation in engaging with and amplifying the artistic works online.

Theatre practitioners are increasingly adopting digital platforms such as Facebook, WhatsApp, TikTok, and Instagram to record, upload, promote, and circulate performances in digital spaces. However, the central concern in recent scholarship is how these digital tools influence audience participation in theatre productions. Mark's study of Tosin Jobi-Tume's *Corona Palava* highlights this shift during the COVID-19 pandemic, when live performances were suspended, and theatre makers turned to Facebook to stream productions. Using the Arts Audience Experience Index (Radbourne et al., 2009), Mark identified four dimensions of digital audience experience that shaped how Nigerian audiences, especially Bolt drivers in Port Harcourt, interacted with online theatre. The study shows that well-crafted framing texts accompanying performances reduced uncertainties, increased appreciation, and encouraged repeat engagement.

Mark's emphasis on digital audience experience aligns with the broader notion of digital cultural labour, where audiences do not simply consume content but actively participate in its circulation and meaning-making. When viewers share rehearsal clips, comment on trailers, or remix snippets on TikTok, they are performing unpaid labour that extends the visibility of theatre productions. Nwafor and Eyefia argue that such participatory engagements strengthen the relational bonds between theatre and its audiences by turning passive

spectators into active co-creators of cultural meaning (118). Their view resonates with Jenkins's concept of "participatory culture," which describes how digital media environments empower audiences to play productive roles in shaping cultural products (3).

This participatory culture is especially significant in Nigerian university theatres because these theatres often lack the financial resources for large-scale marketing. Digital participation by audiences, even though seemingly small acts like reposting flyers or creating memes around productions, substitutes for traditional advertising costs and becomes a form of collective labour sustaining the theatre. However, this labour is not always consciously cultivated by theatre marketers. Many Nigerian university theatres continue to treat digital platforms as notice boards, rather than interactive arenas where audiences' digital contributions are integral to the production ecosystem.

The experience of the 2025 Festival of Plays at Ekiti State University further illustrates this gap. While digital publicity created visibility, only a few productions, particularly *Women of Owu*, went beyond one-way communication to foster dialogue and audience resonance. The high turnout for *Women of Owu* suggests that when audiences perceive themselves as emotionally and narratively invested through pre-performance digital engagement, they are more likely to attend and participate actively. This outcome reinforces Radbourne, Glow, and Johanson's proposition that reducing uncertainty and enhancing anticipation through interactive digital strategies deepens both cognitive and emotional engagement (132).

Thus, audience participation in Nigerian university theatres is increasingly tied to digital cultural labour, where spectators become collaborators in visibility, marketing, and meaning-making. Yet, the inconsistency in how this labour is recognized and integrated underscores the urgent need for structured training in digital storytelling, content management, and participatory strategies.

Methodology

This paper is based on a field study of the 2025 Festival of Plays of the Department of Theatre and Media Arts, Ekiti State University. A qualitative research approach is employed to examine how digital platforms, such as

TikTok and WhatsApp, were used to market the 2025 Festival of Plays and connect with audiences. Participant observation was conducted between April 1st and 15th, 2025, to document marketing activities of the 11 productions. As an observer in the marketing activities, the researcher monitored how the marketing teams of each production planned and executed digital marketing strategies. Also, semi-structured interviews were conducted with eleven (11) student production managers responsible for the non-artistic components of the plays and audience to gain insights into the strategies employed, the challenges faced, and the success recorded. In addition to that, a short semi-structured conversations was conducted with the audience to capture their motivations for attending, their impressions of the online promotional materials, and the extent to which the digital marketing influenced their decision to watch the performance. Audience engagement metrics on TikTok posts, WhatsApp broadcasts, and E-flyers were also reviewed alongside ticketing and attendance data to establish connections between online activity and physical turnout. The responses and reactions of followers and users on 176 TikTok posts on the Eksutma page, and WhatsApp broadcast on the Faculty of Arts Social platform were analysed.

2025 Festival of Plays at the Department of Theatre and Media Arts, Ekiti State University

The 2025 Festival of Plays of the Department of Theatre and Media Arts, Ekiti State University, was an avenue for students to gain practical experience in theatre production. This process is led by the final-year students who took charge of the artistic, technical, and managerial aspects of each performance. The festivals took place between 4th and 16th April, 2025 and opened with Femi Osifisan's *Women of Owu* and Tegonni, which tells a powerful tales of Euripides' *The Trojan Women* set in post-war Yoruba land, and highlights the tension between personal freedom and cultural expectations respectively. Other highlights of the festival are Osofisans's *Red is the Freedom Road*, Olabayo's *Sarzcrosant*, Olu Dolapo's *Seven Virgins*, Ola Rotimi's *Grip Am*, Lara Owoeye's *No Honourable at Night*, Ola Awakan's *Echoes of the Drums*, Ahmed Yerima's *King Liadi*, and Efunsetan Aniwura: *Iyalode Ibadan* written by Sesan Akinwunmi. More information about the performances is captured in the table below:

Performance	Central Theme	Date Presented
<i>Women of Owu</i>	Resilience of women	4 th April
<i>Tegonni</i>	Resistance to colonial power	7 th April
<i>Red is the Freedom...</i>	Struggle for social justice	8 th April
<i>Sarcrosanct</i>	Hope and resistance	9 th April
<i>Seven Virgins</i>	Fight for autonomy in a patriarchal society	10 th April
<i>Grip Am</i>	Justice, accountability, and moral integrity	11 th April
<i>No Honourable....</i>	Ambition, and the consequences of betrayal	14 th April
<i>Echoes of the Drums</i>	The power of tradition	14 th April
<i>Ayelala</i>	Human cost of Betrayal	15 th April
<i>King Liadi</i>	Governance, tradition, betrayal, and power	16 th April
<i>Efunsetan</i>	Ambition, political authority, and gendered legacy	17 th April

Source(s): Author

Table 1. Central Themes of Performances and Date Presented

Marketing Strategies of the Ekiti State University Theatre 2025 Festival of Plays
The marketing activities for the 2025 Festival of Plays were spearheaded by Theatre Management students, who were responsible for planning, coordinating, and executing all promotional efforts. The students divided themselves into specialized groups such as Ticket Sales, Publicity, and Social Media Management, to manage the workload effectively and ensure timely delivery. Each group took ownership of specific aspects of the marketing

process and worked collaboratively to promote the productions.

The marketing process began approximately one month before the festival commenced. During this period, the students experimented with various theatre marketing strategies, selecting approaches that aligned with the themes and styles of the individual productions. A hybrid marketing approach that combines both traditional and digital tools was adopted to ensure wider reach and audience engagement.

Traditional strategies included the design and placement of posters and banners at key locations across the university campus. These were strategically positioned in areas such as lecture halls, hostels, and relaxation spots, to draw the attention of the university community. These materials served as the first point of contact for many potential audience members within the school environment.

Digitally, the team engaged the audience through TikTok, and WhatsApp. E-flyers were circulated through status updates and direct messages on WhatsApp. The E-flyers were designed to pass information such as the name of the play, time, date, venue, and ticket price, and were shared with students and staff of the University via different WhatsApp groups like TMA Family, Faculty Board of Arts, and Phoenix Class of 25, among others. Below are samples of flyers shared on whatsapp.



Source (s): Adebiyi, 2025

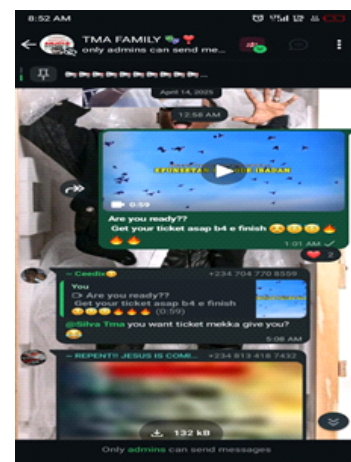


Plate 1: E-Flyers of *Efunsetan*:

Iyalode Ibadan broadcast on TMA Family WhatsApp Group (Adebiyi, 2025).

The E-flyers are posted at 9 am and repeated at 10 pm with different captions for diverse audiences. This is done to capture as much of the audience as possible within the limited time frame, and get direct feedback and review from online audiences. However, due to the structure of the flyers, not all audience members engaged with the flyers. **In plate 1**, the caption written for the flyers reads: "For those who don't know bout this story, this is Iyalode Efunsetan Aniwura of Ibadan land, a woman with different stories. Anticipate. Secure your VIP or VVIP ticket and enjoy an exclusive premium seating, priority entry, and a front-row view of this unforgettable performance." The analysis of the captions indicate that the marketing is focused on ticket sales, as they emphasize the ticket price more than the unforgettable experience that can emotionally connect the audience to the performance. Sadly, this is the pattern of writing caption for virtually all the posts made on the WhatsApp group analysed for this study. This pattern sent the wrong signal to the audience, who felt that they are only needed to buy tickets and see shows. The interaction with the selected audience on the red carpet confirmed that the content of the e-flyers focused on transactional details (name of the play, date, venue, and ticket price) without creating room for dialogue or interactive communication. As a result, while the flyers were effective in sharing information, they did not generate significant audience engagement because they appealed only to attendance decisions rather than fostering conversation, anticipation, or a sense of community.

Also, the team launched a dedicated Eksutma page on TikTok, which became the central hub for the festival's digital publicity. They uploaded behind-the-scenes content, audition clips, cast rehearsals, and audience reactions to build anticipation and personalize the productions. Within a short time, the Eksutma TikTok page attracted 881 followers and garnered over 11,000 likes, demonstrating a strong level of digital engagement and interest from both students and external audiences. The platform was used to publicize all eleven (11) productions, offering visual previews that brought the productions to life at the pre-production stage.

About 285 posts were made to promote the eleven (11) performances at different times and dates. Out of the 285 posts available on the TikTok page, a random sample of 176 posts was selected for analysis. This approach made the analysis more manageable within the scope of the study, while still providing

sufficient data to identify trends and draw valid conclusions about audience reactions. For this study, the 176 randomly selected posts were examined across 16 cycles to determine the frequency with which each performance was posted and the reactions they received from users and followers. Below is a table that captures data collected on user and follower reactions on each post within the organized 16 cycles.

Performance	No of Posts Made	Views	Likes	Comments	Share
<i>Women of Owu</i>	17	11,753	2,183	53	9
<i>Tegonni</i>	20	2,283	315	44	35
<i>Red...</i>	18	2,081	353	15	13
<i>Sacrosanct</i>	10	2,865	1,033	16	72
<i>Seven Virgins</i>	21	1,913	268	17	10
<i>Grip Am</i>	19	2,776	793	2	2
<i>No Honorable at Night</i>	13	1,024	97	16	4
<i>Echoes of the Drums</i>	6	958	124	2	24
<i>Ayelala</i>	19	1,713	273	7	2
<i>King Liadi</i>	12	1,457	253	6	12
<i>Efunsetan...</i>	23	11,750	2,760	18	3

Source (s): Adebisi, 2025

Table 2: Performances and their digital metrics

The data in the table highlights significant variations in the behaviours of the users and followers towards the posts of each performance. The reactions across categories reveal varied audience behaviors. While likes were the most common form of engagement across all performances, comments and shares

were far less frequent. *Women of Owu* had the highest comment count (53), suggesting it sparked discussion, whereas *Sacrosanct* recorded the highest number of shares (72), which shows that its content had viral appeal beyond immediate followers. Thus, showing a varied degree of audience engagement. Below is the table with performance and the average views gotten per post ($\text{views} \div \text{posts}$) and rate of engagement ($\text{likes} \div \text{views} \times 100$)

Performance	Average views per post (Approx.)	Engagement rate
<i>Women of Owu</i>	691 views	18.6%
<i>Tegonni</i>	114 views	13%
<i>Red is the Freedom...</i>	116 views	17%
<i>Sacrosanct</i>	286 views	36%
<i>Seven Virgins</i>	91 views	14%
<i>Grip Am</i>	146 views	28.6%
<i>No Honourable...</i>	79 views	9.5%
<i>Echoes of the Drums</i>	160 views	13%
<i>Ayelala</i>	90 views	16%
<i>King Liadi</i>	121 views	17.3%
<i>Efunsetan</i>	511 views	23.5%

Source (s): Adebisi, 2025

Table 3: Analysis of Performance based on Audience Engagement of the Online Content

The analysis above shows that digital engagement directly influenced audience perception and turnout. Productions with higher engagement (*Women of Owu*, *Efunsetan*, and *Sacrosanct*) corresponded with stronger physical attendance during the live performances, while the plays with low digital traction struggled to attract comparable patronage. The table below provides the statistics of audiences per production:

Performance	Number of attendees
<i>Women...</i>	436
<i>Tegonni</i>	361
<i>Red is...</i>	280
<i>Sarcrosanct</i>	364
<i>Seven virgins</i>	322
<i>Grip am</i>	298
<i>No honourable</i>	141
<i>Echoes of drums</i>	243
<i>Ayelala</i>	303
<i>King liadi</i>	264
<i>Efunsetan</i>	352

Source (s): Adebisi, 2025

Table 4: Audiences Attendance per Performance

The table above shows that *Women of Owu* attracted the highest number of audience, while *No Honorable at Night* got the least number of audience. From my interaction with the production managers, I discovered that people,

especially women, feel more connected to the content about *Women of Owu* posted online, and can resonate with the ordeals of the characters. Even, when the data of the audience that attended *Women of Owu* was analysed, it is discovered there are more female than male, and the people interviewed during the red carpets said they came to see the performance because they hope to see themselves in the performance, and that the trailers and teasers of the performance they saw online really motivated them to come and share the pains and experiences of the Owu women.

Evidently, a glimpse of what is possible in terms of digital communication was seen in the production of *Women of Owu*. While other groups used digital tools mostly for publicity, the marketing team of *Women of Owu* production went a bit ahead to create dialogue even before the play started. They subconsciously used the digital platforms as spaces for conversation, and this contributed to the high audience turnout. Overall, productions that received consistent and visually engaging digital promotion, particularly through TikTok and WhatsApp, recorded higher audience turnout, suggesting a clear link between targeted online engagement and physical attendance at performances.

Challenges Encountered in the Digital Marketing Process

Despite the evident enthusiasm and innovation demonstrated by the student marketers, several challenges hindered the full optimization of digital tools during the 2025 Festival of Plays. One of the most prominent issues was inconsistent content creation. While some productions had engaging promotional videos, rehearsal clips, and actor interviews uploaded regularly, others suffered from sparse or delayed online presence. This disparity often stemmed from unequal commitment levels among student marketers, time constraints, or lack of coordination between production and publicity teams.

Another major obstacle was the limited technical expertise among some members of the social media team. Although most students were familiar with using platforms like WhatsApp and TikTok for personal use, many lacked formal training in crafting targeted content, optimizing engagement through hashtags and algorithms, or analyzing metrics to improve visibility. As a result, some digital content failed to reach its intended audience or lacked the professional quality that could have made it more compelling.

A third challenge was the absence of a structured publicity plan. The festival

marketing team did not work with a content calendar or predefined publicity roadmap. This led to overlapping posts, uneven timing of uploads, and missed opportunities for building narrative continuity across productions. For instance, certain productions were publicized heavily in the early days of the festival, while others received little attention until the day of performance. This inconsistency negatively impacted overall attendance.

In addition, resource constraints, such as limited access to high-quality recording equipment, professional lighting, or video editing software, restricted the students' ability to create content that matched the visual standards commonly found on popular digital platforms. In a space where attention is earned through aesthetics and clarity, this puts some productions at a disadvantage.

Finally, network connectivity issues occasionally delayed uploads and disrupted livestream efforts when the team tried to engage real-time audiences. This challenge is a broader infrastructural problem common in many Nigerian academic environments that must be acknowledged when planning digital initiatives.

The Shifting Logics of Theatre Marketing in Nigerian Universities

The findings from the 2025 Festival of Plays at the Department of Theatre and Media Arts, Ekiti State University, indicate both the prospects and limitations of digital theatre marketing in Nigerian universities. The festival experience revealed that social media platforms such as TikTok and WhatsApp serve other functions beyond channels for casual interaction. They can become active tools for theatre publicity and engagement. Productions that maximized these tools, particularly *Women of Owu* as directed by Emmanuella Bakare, achieved higher attendance and generated conversations that extended beyond physical performance spaces. The outcome of the marketing of this production resonates with the Attention Economy theory, where audience loyalty is increasingly tied to the ability of theatre producers to capture and sustain interest across fragmented digital environments.

Conclusion

This study examined the use of digital platforms in marketing the 2025 Festival of Plays at Ekiti State University to investigate the possibilities and limitations of student-led strategies. The findings demonstrate that while platforms like

TikTok and WhatsApp created visibility, most content remained transactional and unidirectional, functioning more as announcements than as spaces for dialogue. Productions that attempted interactive strategies, particularly *Women of Owu*, attracted higher audience engagement and attendance, underscoring the value of emotionally resonant and participatory campaigns.

The results confirm that effective digital theatre marketing requires more than publicity; it depends on cultivating trust, commitment, and dialogue with audiences. To achieve this, this study recommends that Nigerian university theatres should invest in capacity-building workshops on digital storytelling, campaign management, and audience analysis. They should also establish dedicated digital publicity units with structured content calendars and technical support to further enhance consistency and impact.

Conclusively, this study highlights the urgent need for Nigerian university theatres to embrace digital platforms as dynamic spaces for conversation, participation, and co-creation. This will lead to enhanced digital marketing practices within university theatres, help increase visibility, and ensure lasting audience relationships essential for the sustainability of theatre in the digital age.

Works Cited

- Boh, A., and T. J. Adoka. "Artistic Creativity, Digital Technologies and Theatrical Sustainability: Integrating New Media in Theatre Practice." *Nigerian Theatre Journal: A Journal of the Society of Nigeria Theatre Artists (SONTA)* 23.1-2 (2023): 27-37. Print.
- Ekweariri, C. S. "Marketing the Arts through Effective Branding and Packaging Techniques in Nigeria: The Role of Designers." *Marketing Contemporary Nigerian Theatre and Cultural Entertainment*. Ed. S. E. Ododo and O. A. Fosudo. Maiduguri: Society of Nigeria Theatre Artists (SONTA), 2014. Print.
- Ford, V., and M. Mandviwalla. "Can Digital Engagement Transform the Performing Arts?" *Proceedings of the 53rd Hawaii International Conference on System Sciences (HICSS)*. 2020. Web. 12 Sept. 2025 <https://doi.org/10.24251/HICSS.2020.526>
- Jenkins, Henry. *Convergence Culture: Where Old and New Media Collide*. NYU Press, 2006.

- Mark, Tekena. "Digital Audience Engagement in Nigeria: A Shift from Live to Online Audience Experience in Tosin Jobi-Tume's *Corona Palava*." *Arts and the Market*, vol. 13, no. 2, 2023, pp. 80-93, Emerald Publishing Limited, <https://doi.org/10.1108/AAM-06-2022-0029>
- Maulidiyanti, M., L. F. Hawadi, P. Suciati, and N. R. Wiwesa. "Effective Social Marketing Strategies for Social Changes." *Proceedings of the International Conference on Vocational Education Applied Science and Technology (ICVEAST 2023)*. Ed. D. V. Ferezagia et al. 2023. Print.
- Nwafor, F., and G. O. Eyefia. "The New Media and Theatre Marketing: An Example of the Play Production of Odumegege by Miesoinuma Minima." *International Journal of Language, Literature and Gender Studies (LALIGENS)* 8.2 (2019): 115-22. Web. 12 Sept. 2025 <https://doi.org/10.4314/laligens.v8i2.11>
- Radbourne, J., Johnson, K., Glow, H., and White, T. "The Audience Experience: Measuring Quality in the Performing Arts", *International Journal of Arts Management*, vol. 1, no. 3, 2009, pp. 16-29.
- Scholz, Rebor. "Why Does Digital Labour Matter Now?" *Digital Labour: The Internet as Playground and Factory*. Routledge, 2013. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9780203145791>
- Seaman, B., and Critchlow, K. "Effective Strategies Used by Trinidad and Tobago Financial Institution Leaders to Attract and Retain SMEs", *Open Journal of Business and Management*, vol. 13, no. 3, 2025, pp. 1811-1824. <https://doi.org/10.4236/ojbm.2025.133094>
- Terranova, Tiziana. "Free Labour: Producing Culture for the Digital Economy." *Social Text*, vol. 18, no. 2, 2000, pp. 33-58. Duke University Press, <https://doi.org/10.1215/01642472-18-2>
- Tonkoshkura, O. "Theatre in the Age of Digital Technologies." *Artistic Culture: Topical Issues* 18.2 (2022): 30-34. Print.
- Zehra, S., Karamat, K., and Qureshi, N. "Theatre in the Digital Age: Challenges and Audience Viewing Experiences", *Pakistan Journal of Social Research*, vol. 5, no. 1, 2023, pp. 609-616.